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## YODGAR

The hot days of summer. I'm wearing a simple, chest-open cotton robe with a wick sewn into the collar. "A *chust duppi*<sup>1</sup> is on my head, a silk sash is around my waist and soft-soled chrome leather boots are on my feet.' I'm walking along one of the long, narrow garden-lined streets. The dusty, quiet road feels dull. The shadows of the trees stand motionless, not drifting a single step beyond their own bounds. Over the tall blind clay walls branches of peaches, apricots and sometimes branches of mountain grapes are hanging down into the street. Every ten or fifteen steps, small irrigation ditches cross the street – emerging from a courtyard wall on one side and disappearing under the clay wall on the other with no bridges in sight. I am walking down a street where not even a fly has flown, silent and still. The destination is still far. I try singing simple melodies as I walk, though some stanzas of the song seem to melt into the hot air, losing their zest and charm

At the other end of the street a woman with a *paranji*<sup>2</sup> appeared. She is moving towards me. She is coming along with her face uncovered, holding her eastern shawl swaying and dancing like a fan. She doesn't shy away from the sight of a man approaching her, negligent, careless. I am also

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1. **Chust duppi** [ʃʃust duppi] – is a tall traditional Uzbek national cap (skullcap) unique to the city of Chust in Uzbekistan, distinguished by its distinctive decorations and unique patterns. They are adorned with traditional ornaments such as description of almond and pepper), with each duppi considered a unique work of art. Chust duppis are mainly worn by the residents of Andijan, Samarkand, Osh, Jalal-Abad, Dushanbe and Khujand.

2. **Paranji** – is a traditional Central Asian robe, often with a veil, that covers the head and body of women.

walking alone through the silent street. I feel like teasing her with a few playful words, just to shake off the boredom that's been weighing on me all this time. The woman with a paranji continues to approach me... There are no more than ten steps left before we meet face-to-face. I keep my eyes fixed on her, and she seems to do the same.

There, on her bright red, petite lips, wild traces of the half-smile that captivated me earlier still linger. She tries to conceal her laughter with modesty, but the laughter hidden on her lips now plays in her dark eyes. The heat of the day has made her pomegranate-like cheeks flush and swell. On her wide and fair forehead – like the paths of happiness – tiny beads of sweat glisten like pearls.

We draw closer – just one more second, and she'll step aside for me and I for her. Then we'll each go our separate ways. No, it didn't happen like that. She stopped. For a moment, her gaze swept over me from head to toe.

– Hold on, *Mulla aka*<sup>3</sup>.

Her voice rang out like the clear sound of a precious crystal bowl.

– What can I do for you, my darling?

– Have you ever learned to serve someone selflessly?

A man's strength lies in honesty. So far, I have never served anyone except selflessly

    If I am worthy of your service, I would be pleased.

3. **Mulla aka** – is a respectful and affectionate term used in Central Asian cultures, especially in Uzbekistan, to refer to an elderly or learned Muslim man, often a religious scholar, imam or community spiritual leader. The word “Mulla” denotes someone knowledgeable in Islamic teachings, while “aka” means “elder brother,” adding a tone of respect and familiarity. Together, Mulla aka conveys both reverence and warmth toward elderly people.

“Then, find a more secluded spot, and I will tell you what I need

Not far from this street, there is a small prayer hall without rugs and carpets, a simple front pavilion (*Ayvan*)<sup>4</sup>, and a mosque with a courtyard, through which a small stream flows. The mosque would be empty, like a house that has been abandoned, on all days of the week except Friday.” One by one, we entered through the single-panel door ...

The girl went and sat at the entrance of the porch. I squatted on the edge of the ditch opposite her... The girl took a small silk handkerchief out of the sleeves of her dress that rolled up to her marble-like wrists, and began to wipe away the dew-like fresh sweat that had settled on the tip of her nose and above her lips. The scent of water-soaked clove suddenly wafted from the handkerchief. Since the mosque was built, this is probably the first time the scent of love and maturity has filled the air here. The girl frowned slightly, looked me over once, and saw me out ...

– Are you married?

– No.

– That’s good; won’t you marry me?

This sudden proposal caught me entirely off guard.

– Is this your idea of service?

The girl burst into laughter...

– Are you really saying You’ve learned to serve someone selflessly?

If you command it, I’m ready to tie an elephant with a hair (to tie an ant to an elephant) or move a mountain with a fingernail.

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4. **Ayvan** – is a large, vaulted hall or space, walled on three sides and open on one side, often leading into a courtyard or other rooms.

– Well then, – said the girl, pausing in thought, – alright, I’ll tell you everything. Listen carefully.

I listened intently to these lines which recorded heartbeats on the golden pages of the book of youth, gazing at the small stream flowing like the gentle waves of life. It was as if she were telling the tales of Shahrazad from *Alf Layla wa Laylata* in a morning that had yet to lose its blessings.

– My parents are old-fashioned people. To them, love is as insignificant as an empty walnut shell. They married me off according to their own decision. My husband has no steady job; he is a covert petty merchant. It’s been over a year since I’ve been in his chains. I spend sorrowful nights that bleed into mornings full of grief. He is indifferent. For him, love is nothing more than a pillow. For me, living even a minute with him feels unbearable. I want to divorce him. You know well that in a traditional family, divorcing a girl is considered a great disgrace. My husband also fights me tooth and nails to our divorce. Sometimes he comes home dead drunk and beats me. Then if I say, “If you’re tired of me, let me go,” he replies, “I’ll chain you up until your hair turns grey.” I am still young. Like my peers, I want to have a fun. A week ago, there was yet another usual quarrel. This time, my husband cursed me to the depths of my ancestors’ graves and hit me for not ironing his trousers. This time, it hurt me deeply. I even thought of running away somewhere... – the woman said, tears welling up in her eyes

I thought to myself, “Oh no! If she says, “Take me away,” where would I take her?” With this vague thought, I asked:

– So, what do you plan to do now?

In the yard of the mosque, the woman once again unfolded her handkerchief, releasing the warm scent of cloves. She wiped the tears clinging to her curly eyelashes. In a half-

sobbing voice, she said: “I had been watching for several days and finally managed to steal my husband’s passport. Take this and be my husband for an hour.”

– What do you mean?

What exactly is my role here?”

The sorrow on her face was replaced by a half-deceptive mischievous smile:

– As if you were my husband, and you will go to the registry office to give me a *talaq*<sup>5</sup> (divorce me).

I suddenly felt strangely unsettled. The little stream that had just moments ago comforted me with its ripples now seemed to flow in reverse

The scent of cloves soaked in water felt as sharp in my stomach as garlic. I was confused

– How can it be possible?

The young woman would have tried to overcome my doubt with her grace, intending to charm away this hesitation with her arrogant laughter.

From the way she now stared at me without breaking eye contact, it was as if she was silently saying, “I will defeat you!”

– Isn’t your heart brave enough to handle this, young man? Then, with a *duppi*<sup>6</sup> and a *sash*<sup>7</sup>, you only seem to have

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5. **Talaq** – is to formally divorce one’s wife in accordance with Islamic law (Sharia). Talaq (Arabic: *تلاط*) literally means “*repudiation*” or “*release*”. It is a legal term in Islamic jurisprudence referring to the husband’s right to end a marriage by pronouncing “talaq” (divorce).

6. “**Duppi**” refers to a traditional Central Asian skullcap, particularly common in Uzbek culture. It is a round or slightly square-shaped cap, often embroidered with colorful or symbolic patterns.

7. **Belbog** – is a strip of cloth tied around the **waist** to hold clothing in place or as an accessory, literally means “sash.”

a proud posture.

– The heart may be brave enough, but having never even been married, how can I just get divorced?! This situation is like preparing a wooden stake before the calf is even born.

The woman burst into laughter. At the sound of this laughter, two pigeons, which had been perching on the mosque roof's ridge flew away in fright

– Well, let yours be in reverse way.

First, we prepare a stake, then we will find a calf. First divorce, then marriage.

– Really?

The woman suddenly turned serious. The kindness in her words was replaced by intensity. With a regretful tone, she said:

– What a pity, what a man you are. I had asked for selfless service from a right man, but alas, my secrets have been in vain. Come, let's exchange the "paranji" for a chapan.

After hearing this, I felt a sense of shame. I considered breaking my earlier promise to be dishonorable to my name as a man. She had truly won me over.

– So, what do you want me to do now?

Her eyes sparkled with triumph.

– With your clumsiness, you might embarrass me at the civil registry office as well. Fine, let's take a risk. Listen carefully. Keep this passport with you. We'll go to Civil registry office together. Through the door, we will enter cursing each other. You say "I do divorce", I say "I do leave you. If the staff at the registry office try to reconcile us and give advice, we won't give in. You stick to your word. I'll curse you, insult you, but don't get upset. You can also insult me once or twice ... Just hand me the divorce paper, that's

all ...

The widowed woman, smooth and sly as a fox, talked endlessly until I was under her spell, completely dazed. The two of us headed towards the registry office together.

Half an hour later, we were *trading fiery barbs* and raising a ruckus in the cramped office of the registry. She calls me a “speculator”. I call her “arrogant, shameless”. The staff at the registry office try to calm us down, attempting to reconcile us as much as they can. I won’t give in. She is being stubborn. In the end, even the staff at the registry office were at a loss. They wanted to quickly give us our divorce paper to get themselves out of the quarrel. They didn’t subject us to much pressure or interrogation either. They took my passport and began writing the divorce paper.

At least, the document was officially stamped. Copies were made. One copy was handed to her, another to me.

Paying the fees, I sighed deeply and said:

– “Thank God I’ve escaped such a miserable life!” May I not remarry again.

The woman, holding her divorce paper, also sighed:

At last, there are days when the world shines bright. If this is what it means to be a husband, then let the earth take it.

The staff at the marriage registry office looked at our exchange with a mixture of pity and indifference.

No one said a word.

Once the work was done, we shot bitter looks at each other and stepped out onto the street. Outside, she leaned toward me and, with a playful tone, said:

– Thank you. You’re even more mischievous than I



thought. But I feel the job is still half-done. If it's not too inconvenient, could you wait for me at the marriage registry office entrance for ten minutes? I'll be back soon.

The task should be completed properly. Oh, by the way, hand me the passport. It won't be needed to you anymore."

Foolish and gullible as I was, I fell for it and said:

Alright, but please hurry back.

She got on the tram and left. I kept waiting. True to her word, she returned quickly. Yet, tucked under her arm, inside her paranji, she seemed to be carrying something.

—Let's go, she said. "We'll go back to the marriage registry office and wrap up the unfinished matter.

We went back in. We approached the table where the divorce was to be finalized. The woman took out the bundle from under her arm. My eyes nearly popped out of their sockets. It was a newborn baby — a little child, wrapped in pure white swaddling, peacefully sucking on a pacifier, completely carefree and unaware of everything else

I looked at her with questioning eyes. She, stubborn as the devil, glanced sharply at the marriage registry officer and said:

— Well, since he divorced me, let him take care of his child too. I won't waste my youth raising a baby. If necessary, let him raise the child himself. "Not even worth the sacrifice of a dog!" she said, then shoved the child into my arms and stormed out onto the street. I stood there, frozen, holding the child in stunned silence. What am I supposed to do now? I would be in trouble if I said, "Hey brothers, this woman is not my wife. I was just hired to divorce her, and I don't even know if the child is a boy or a girl yet." I would have ended

up in far worse trouble – maybe even faced criminal charges. I was stunned. Almost in tears, I said:

– But what am I supposed to do now? Where should I take this? – I said, and then got scared by my own words. The staff of the registry office looked at me with contempt, and one of them snapped:

– After ruining the life of such a young woman, you might as well bear the consequences too. Pay for your sin, brother, he said sarcastically.

Another tried to console me:

– Don't worry – by law, a nursing baby is given to the mother. Eventually, once your wife's anger fades, her maternal instincts will awaken, and she'll return to reclaim her baby.

I was completely shattered. Not even trusting my legs, I dragged myself as I walked. That day, many people saw me wandering aimlessly through the long, wide, busy city street carrying a child. I went back and forth along the street several times. Just like people who have lost something, I was anxious and out of my mind. From time to time, I look at the baby. If the swaddle covers the face, I tilt it to open it slightly so the baby doesn't have trouble breathing. The baby is breathing softly and beautifully. His pacifier had fallen out of the mouth. Perhaps he was savoring the last lingering taste of his mother's milk. Suddenly, he opened his tiny, dark, bead-like eyes. The pupils of his eyes are restless, not staying fixed on one point. A faint restlessness flickered across his soft, cotton-like face. I wonder if the baby was hungry or if the diaper had gotten wet – he started crying.

– What could I do? After all, it's impossible to carry a

starving baby around the streets until he grows up and find his parents! Some urgent measure needs to be taken. The baby’s crying urges me to come to a decision quickly. Behind his mother’s betrayal, I revived the shattered discipline of my youth once again. What is done cannot be undone. Now, no matter what, the baby must be rescued alive. After all, what fault does this baby have? The fault lies with the parents. I gathered my senses. I made a firm decision. Holding the child in my arms, I got on the tram. I am heading home. The baby felt very uncomfortable in the tram.

The baby whimpers intermittently, searching for the familiar warmth of his mother’s embrace. I press him to my chest. But I don’t have the scent he is searching for. The baby cried louder. Passengers began to feel disturbed. I feel embarrassed. One of them said:

Brother, give the child to its mother; let the little one nurse from her.

He has no mother” I replied.

Another one sniffled and said:

– Leaving the mother at home and wandering around the streets with a young child is really pointless.

I give a vague answer, saying, “The mother was ill; I took the child to have some treatment”.

There are rarely found as talkative people as the tram passengers in the world. They take turns speaking, each tossing in their own opinion about the child. Some treat me like a fool, while others seem to feel sorry for my desperate situation. The one sitting beside me even got up in annoyance and left. While the baby and I stayed on one side, two people got into an argument. One said, ‘It’s good when a baby cries

– it makes his eyes darker,’ while the other replied, ‘No, it’s better if he doesn’t cry – too much crying causes eye problems. By the time it came to swearing, we – the new father and child – got off the tram.

When I entered through the door, a rope was stretched between the kitchen and the veranda’s pillar, with my brothers’ large and small shirts and trousers were hung to dry, and the old woman was sitting on a washing basin. The old woman saw me coming in holding the child by the hand and seemed to think that I am bringing my sisters along, then asked:

– Have you again bring some guests? Who’s coming? Are you bringing Savri, Rahbar, or your brother’s children along? You, my child, are indeed very kind-hearted and generous – so kind to your brothers and sisters. And now, once again, your little brothers’ laundry will be left undone, – she said.

The baby, who had just slightly calmed down, started crying again. The old woman, standing by the basin, tried to soothe the baby.

– Hush now, hush little grandchild, don’t cry, don’t cry. Look, your grandma will dry her hands in just a moment, my chubby little one, and I’ll hold you close to my heart!

The old woman shook the soapy foam from her hands into the basin, stood up, and took the grandchild from my arms. Looking at me, she asked:

Hey, my child, why are you so down? Just tell me – who’s coming?

I said nothing.

The old woman embraced the child with the kind of

love and affection only mothers who have raised dozens of children possess – family care had become her true calling. She often used to say:

– Strength lies either in the bone or in the flesh. Thank God mine was in the bone – if not, how could I have raised six children? I never understood anything from that simple statement.

O mother, who nurtured me with your heart, o mother, who gave me your very being, O mother, whose tear-filled eyes never closed for my upbringing! O mother, whose fate was drowned in the darkness of black nights, o mother, whose bright days were blessed with happiness for my future! Who in this world is more loving than a mother? To this day, I haven't been able to write a poem as sweet as the lullabies you sang above my cradle. To this day, I haven't felt a sorrow equal to the worries you bore over my smallest fever.

My mother believed the baby was the child of one of my sisters or my brother. The poor woman is now sixty-two years old. Her lifetime seems to have gotten caught somewhere in the shadowy branches of my distant past, like the hems of girls picking apples snagged on tree limbs. The ray in her eyes has been divided among us, six children, as she kept gazing into our eyes over the years. She couldn't recognize the baby right away. In her own words, my mother now an “elderly woman of dignity, thought “it must be one of my grandchildren”.

Mother, I said, quit this baby's crying, the mother hasn't come yet and won't be back anytime soon.

The old woman scolded me, saying, you never stop meddling in everything, my son; your love for the little ones

has worn me out too. Why do you take a baby who's still breastfeeding away from its mother? What am I supposed to give it now? Your sister-in-law is also so careless and doesn't appreciate the child's worth. "If you live long enough, you'll mature and eventually come down from your high horse" they say. Once youth's wild fire settles down, maybe they will finally understand the value of a child. But as the saying goes, "A mother's heart is with her child, while the child's heart is out in the world".

The baby was constantly crying. The old woman forgot both me and the laundry she had been washing. She took the baby in her arms and tried to soothe it by rocking and making various movements. The baby was hungry. It was quite difficult to comfort her with just kindness and no food.

– Oh, young people, young people, said the old woman. She handed me the baby and opened her velvet covered box. She took out a few shriveled almonds and crushed them. After soaking them in hot water, she wrapped the mixture in a gauze headscarf and began to let the baby suck on it.

By chance, at that time, both my elder brother's wife and my younger sister had given birth, so the old woman didn't know whose baby this was. The child calmed down a little. After a while, he started crying again. Even though a couple of hours had passed, there was still no sign of the "guest" the old woman was waiting for. The old woman began to scold me:

– You don't seem like one of us, my son – what kind of boy have you turned out to be? Why on earth are you dragging this poor little baby around, separated from its

mother?

Mother – I said, “shall I tell you the truth? This baby has no mother. No matter how long you wait, she’ll not come.” This... this is my child!

– What? said the old woman. “What are you saying, *good-for-nothing* boy! How could this possibly be your child?!”

– They say people become stubborn when they get old, but once I say my child, then he is truly my child. What’s the point of investigating, just raise it!

– Hey, you, child, what are you saying? After all I’ve been through to get here, have I really ended up being a joke to you, my child? After all, whose child is this really?

I needed to speak a little more firmly to the old woman:

– I said he is my child—end of story! This is my child but you’ll raise it. However, you raised me and my brothers, you will raise him the same way – there’s nothing more to say.

At first, the old woman didn’t believe me. But then, seeing the seriousness on my face, she seemed to understand the meaning of my words a little. Unable to hold herself back, she started sobbing loudly. You’ve shamed my honor, my dear!

– But, – said the old woman, – what am I supposed to do now? You’ve brought shame to all seven of my decency, damned. I had ever praised you to anyone or caused people to speak highly of you behind your back, I had even sent a suitor to your aunt’s daughter and arranged a match, then you, my dear, in the end, come to my house carrying a motherless baby. How am I supposed to endure this humiliation? I have

friends, enemies, neighbors, and fellow villagers. In my old age, I had hoped that my youngest son's wife would be my support — my hands and feet. In the name of Allah, I entrust you to your father's spirit.

Stop worrying so much, mother, I was trying to make you happy, but the baby's mother gave birth and then died...

She would have been a daughter-in-law worth cherishing. She took the baby, unwrapped his swaddle:

– Oh, my little one – you are all soaked down there too!

Well, if you called her a bride – she was one worthy of the name. Who did you marry, after all? Whose child was she? If the baby's mother has passed away. I should go pay my respect. Where is her home? The baby started crying again. While the old woman was chatting with me, the “grandchild” would be left hungry. Wiping the tears of her eyes with the age of scarf, she went over to the baby. She unwrapped the swaddling clothes.

I stood up from my seat and quietly glanced out of the corner of my eye. The baby was a boy with skin as soft as cotton.

From that moment on, a battle began in my heart between anger and love, between revenge and passion.

Be witness, friends: From this moment, he is my son!

During the previous few days, the old woman had not shown much affection to the child.

She gave the child the milk that my younger brothers brought every day from the dairy station, but did so with great distrust. But day by day, it was clear that her affection and love for the child were growing. By the tenth day, I heard her scolding my sisters:



– Hey, Qumri, can’t you see your little brother is crying? Take him for a while till I finish baking the bread!”

Or she would say: “Abdugani, get up, my dear boy. If you don’t go early and bring your little brother’s milk, the day will get hot and it might go off before you get back.

The old woman’s words clearly reflected her growing affection for the child. It gave me a sense of peace. The child’s upbringing was secured. True, although the old woman had raised six boisterous boys in her time, her upbringing was rather old–fashioned. But what choice did I have? As an inexperienced bachelor, I had no means of providing a different method of upbringing. As the saying goes, “A house with a child knows no gossip,” and since my son was brought, our home has found a new sense of amusement. The toy my younger brothers played with after coming back from school were for the baby. Even I, after returning from work, would take the baby in my arms and try to soothe him a little. I softly say, “Lullaby, lullaby,” and then ask, “Give me a smile.

Yet, despite our quiet joy, the child stirred much gossip. I became the target of many reproaches. My aunt, I heard, refused to let her daughter marry me:

– God forbid such a man! she reportedly exclaimed: “I won’t give my daughter to some reckless fellow who walks around with a child from who–knows–where. My daughter is a blossom yet to bloom – a pearl untouched, she says.

The neighbors and passers-by didn’t spare their sarcasm either:

– So, is your son growing up?” they would ask mockingly. I too stubborn to explain, would simply respond:

Thank God,” and walk on.

My elder brother, I was told, had declared behind my back:

– That’s enough – let him stay away from me. I have no brother like that.”

And my elder sister scolded the old woman “At your age, what do you need this for? Hand the baby to him – let him take it wherever he pleases. God forbid – haven’t you heard the saying, “They say raise a sheep, and you’ll eat mutton; raise an orphan, and he’ll draw blood.” One day that little orphan will grow up and bring you a pinch of snuff from the bazaar, and no one will even see it.”

In short, I kept getting blamed by relatives, neighbors, and acquaintances, and I became exhausted; my reputation was tarnished, and anyone who saw me would mock and affect me deeply.

Then, unexpectedly, fate offered me a reprieve. At the age of twenty-two, I was drafted into military service. The local commission handed me the summons from the military enlistment office. I really liked that. My smile stretched ear to ear. I rushed over and got examined by the doctor. Since every part of my body was as strong as it cast from steel, I was accepted as fully fit for service in the highest category. I was overjoyed and couldn’t contain myself. The doctor wrote that I was suitable for both cavalry and infantry. The enlistment office assigned me to the infantry, and I was to be sent to Ashgabat.

When the old woman heard the news, she shed a few quiet tears. During the two or three days I had left at home, I was treated with unusual care. Even the child – once despised

and treated with disdain – became a precious presence in the household. No one would let so much as a draft touch him, guarding him with affectionate respect.

Ever since the baby was brought, he hadn't been given a proper name. In my honor, the old woman began calling him Yadgar. When I asked her:

– Mother, what sort of name is 'Yadgar'? It's so old and forgotten," she couldn't help crying and replied:

– Oh, may your mother's heart be your pillow, my child. You're leaving for the army now – may God protect you from evil eyes, may He humble your enemies. Heaven forbid, may you never fall to a bullet. Stand with your comrades, but never fall. As a precaution, I named your son Yodgor – a small keepsake to remember you by. Thanks to God he was born. When I see him, it's as if I see you. Your scent will never fade from my memory."

Though her words made me smile, out of respect – and knowing the child deserved the best care – I said nothing and comforted her instead.

And so, I set off – my heart pounding with anticipation – into the embrace of a new world I had long awaited: the Red army.

I departed for Ashgabat alongside my peers. When I was conscripted, I was barely more than a literate youth – someone who knew just the basics of arithmetic, a carefree boy in an open-collared shirt, singing away the days.

They accepted us. The clothes I had on from home were already exchanged for a military uniform. For a few days, I couldn't get used to these clothes.

Since I was learning military training with great

enthusiasm, willingly fulfilling my duties, keeping my weapons clean, and maintaining my bed neat and tidy – the commander would occasionally affectionately say:

– That’s how it should be. You will become a good soldier.

In addition to general military education, in the evenings we studied being divided into groups based on our abilities. The teachers were very pleased with me.

Occasionally, a letter would arrive from home – from the old woman. The content was always the same: “We miss you. May no one be left without parents. Yadgar has already found his tongue and never stops saying “Daddy, daddy.” My heart feels crushed,” – things like that. I would also write back and promise to visit as soon as I got a holiday. And so life went on... Day by day, I was becoming stronger, my complexion redder, more robust. I was happy, surrounded by friends. I didn’t know what boredom was. In our regiment, there were guys of different nationalities – Kazakhs, Uzbeks, Tatars, Tajiks, Turkmen – I got along with all of them. More importantly, over the last six months I had worked hard and learned Russian quite well. I could write the address myself for letters sent to my home. Recently, I had a photo taken in full military uniform and sent it to the old woman in an envelope. A few days later, I received a letter from my brother. He wrote that the old woman always holds the photo in her hands. She had shown it to all the neighbors. She would often say “Thank God, even my silly little son has come to his senses and become an officer of the government”. *She is over the moon.*

A year later, I heard the old woman was ill. I submitted

a request and received ten days of leave. I farewelled to my comrades and went to see her. My arrival turned into a celebration at the house.

Even my brother who had previously fallen out with me, sisters and sister-in-law – were there. My son had become a plump, white little boy who was already toddling around. He wouldn't leave my lap and I wouldn't let him go either. Even when I went outside, I carried him. No one mocked me anymore as before saying, "So, how's the groom? Is the little boy growing up?"

My aunt also came to visit. Before leaving, she found a moment alone with the old woman and said: "Is it possible to change destiny? A young man goes through many things. Your silly boy came back a proper gentleman from the military. My dear, every day matchmakers come to my house and ask for my daughter's hand in marriage. I tell them, 'No, my dears, my daughter is too young to marry, and she was already engaged (her cradle is already taken). She's already promised,' and boast that her fiancé is an officer in Ashgabat. When the old woman told me all this, giggling uncontrollably, I replied: "She's still young. No need to rush. As for me, I can't marry for at least another three or four years. My military service isn't over yet, and I plan to study another year or two after that."

– That's right, my dear. No one's saying there'll be a wedding tomorrow. She's just planning these things for future, dear.

Even during the few days I spent in Tashkent, my heart ached with longing for my friends. I missed my beloved regiment terribly. That's why I didn't wait for my full leave to end and returned quickly.

In the second year – both tactical training and general

education became more serious. In particular, I tried hard to finish the secondary education I had left incomplete alongside my military knowledge. By the middle of the year, I was even promoted to a unit commander. Judging by the content of my mother’s letters, she no longer thought of me as a “dead soldier.” She wrote offering her advice: “My dear son, study well, train hard, don’t go astray, and don’t forget your only son”.

Of course, I shall never forget my son Yadgar, nor the stories and sorrows that entwine his life with mine. I wonder what destiny has written for him and me.

Yet when one ponders deeply, it becomes clear: it is not fate that molds people, but people who mold their fate. I am striving with all my heart to shape a future full of light—a destiny bright and unbroken—for both myself and for Yadgar. Perhaps, in this at least, the old woman may find some measure of peace.

Life devoted to work passes by in a flash. We get up early for morning exercises, leaving no time or room for idle thoughts unrelated to our duties. By evening, I often find myself still buried in lesson preparation. Sometimes I stop and can’t believe myself. Is this really me? Just recently, I was a simple fellow who thought the joys of life were a lively quail, a pair of fancy boots, a coarse robe, and some good homemade *musallas*<sup>8</sup>. And now—can this truly be me? But today, all my passions have changed. My love, my devotion,

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8. **Musallas** (also spelled **musalla**) – is a traditional Central Asian fermented drink made by fermenting a mixture of grains such as barley or wheat, often combined with water and sometimes flavored with herbs or fruits. Musallas is known for its slightly sour and refreshing taste and is commonly consumed as a nutritious, cooling beverage, especially during hot weather. It has cultural significance and is often homemade using age-old fermentation techniques.

has taken on a new meaning. Now I burn with love for my Motherland. I want to be, and will become, a good son of the nation and of the society that has raised me.

It is the beginning of my twenty-fifth year. The world seems draped in blossoms, covered in tulips and buds. The entire universe seems to smile at me. I shade my eyes and look far into the distance. Beneath my feet lies our majestic homeland, veiled in velvet fields. In the far reaches, her prosperous villages seem to be calling out to me with the spirit of heroism, as if they await my service. What can I call this age of twenty-five? If only I had control over time itself, I would pause it for a few more years and stay right at this age.

Oh, red army, my second mother, who raised me and taught me to face the world with a smile—why has the prime of my youth been so brief? Two years have passed like two warm kisses.

Soon we will be going on extended leave. But I want to stay on as a volunteer. My studies are going intensely. Though I've earned top marks in most subjects, for some reason... I'm weaker in my native language. My teachers sometimes embarrass me. I guess they won't give a failing grade for just one subject anymore.

Many of the young men graduating with us received excellent marks. My commander shows me great kindness. Sometimes I say:

– Comrade Commander, if possible, please allow me to remain in service as a volunteer.”

He smiles, pats me on the shoulder, and gently says:

– I have a different idea for you. I have already spoken to

the relevant parties. After your mandatory service ends, we plan to send you to Leningrad—if you agree. You’ll study at the medical faculty under the military academy. And if you maintain your current dedication and seriousness, in four years you’ll become an excellent military doctor.

Hearing these words fills me with joy. It’s as if a bright and happy future has just unfolded before my eyes. I shake the Comrade commander’s hand firmly and thank him from the bottom of my heart.

True to his word, Comrade commander made it happen. I passed the exams with excellent marks in both military training and other subjects, and I received my leave.

I even got my assignment to the Academy after passing the special commission’s evaluation. My joy is boundless, though it is painful to part with comrades who’ve become like brothers over these two years.

I visited the *Komsomol*<sup>9</sup> unit to collect my documents. At the farewell ceremony held for those going on leave, we hugged our friends, teachers, and commanders tightly, exchanging heartfelt goodbyes. I gave a final salute to my commander, who was both my mentor and my closest companion:

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9. **Komsomol** (short for *Kommunisticheskiy Soyuz Molodyozhi*, or Communist Union of Youth) was the youth division of the Communist Party in the Soviet Union. Established in 1918, Komsomol served as a political and social organization for young people aged roughly 14 to 28. Its main goals were to educate youth in communist ideology, prepare future members of the Communist Party, and involve them in various social, economic, and cultural activities aligned with Soviet policies. Komsomol played a key role in mobilizing young people for labor, military service, education, and propaganda efforts during the Soviet era.



– Comrade Commander, your student will remain forever loyal to his country. I will see myself as a brave Red soldier, ready to defend the homeland from any threat, internal or external. I will always stand guard, like a soldier at his post, to protect and uphold the dignity and prosperity of our socialist nation.

If the Red army, which raised me, expects me to become a military doctor, I will fulfill this duty with excellence.

In Tashkent, my friends, comrades, and relatives welcomed me warmly. Little Yadgar had recently recovered from measles and, not wanting to worry me, they hadn't written about it.

His half-formed speech had started to come out. For example, he couldn't say "peshona" properly — he would say "peshana" instead; he couldn't pronounce the letter "r" at all. If I told him to say "boraman", he would say "boyaman"; if I asked him to say "patron", he'd say "patyon"; and if I told him to say "Aeroplan", he would say "ayupyan". We laugh.

Yadgar is too fascinated by my military uniform and star-studded cap. He puts on my cap, which falls over his eyes, and runs to his grandmother shouting:

Granny, granny! I've become a daddy!

Hopefully, there's no gossip in the house with a child.

When the old woman heard I had completed my military service, she began preparing for a wedding. She would say: "So what if she's young? She's decent enough. I'll raise her myself. I was even younger when I was married. As long as the marriage certificate is obtained, it's fine."

I hadn't yet told my mother that I was going to Leningrad.

I confided in my sister: “Please tell the old woman not to go around announcing the wedding before it’s time. Just because I’ve finished my service doesn’t mean I’ve finished school. I still have three or four years of study left. I said, ‘Just let her know that we’ll talk about it after I finish my studies.

Classes start on the first of September. It was not advisable to waste two and a half months of life for nothing. I visited Tashkent University’s medical faculty to understand the academic standards required for new students and began preparing for Leningrad accordingly.

In the evenings, I’d carry Yadgar. We’d go to parks, visit the circus. I’d put him on the carousel horses, and we’d ride round and round. A cheerful, happy, and blessed life passes very slowly. At first, Yadgar was a little shy when I had just arrived, but in the following days, we grew very close. He couldn’t stand being apart from me. If I wasn’t around for even an hour, he’d throw a tantrum, yelling, “Where’s Daddy?” It’s not good to let the child get too attached to the father. He might take it hard when I leave for Leningrad. The old woman feels the same way.

The days I had long waited for with a pounding heart counting minutes like hours, and hours like days have finally drawn near. I had to be in Leningrad by the twentieth of August.

Today is already the tenth of August. I will depart the day after tomorrow. My sisters and my brother arrived. Their children came along too.

That’s when I realized: if all of grandmother’s descendants gathered in one place, we’d be enough to form a whole neighborhood. The house was as lively as a wedding.

The old woman, together with my sister, was cooking – *bugirsok*<sup>10</sup>, *patir*<sup>11</sup>, *chuzma*<sup>12</sup>, *chalpak*<sup>13</sup> and various other traditional dishes with great care and affection, preparing provisions for my journey. Everyone was preparing to see me off. As for Yadgar, he is playing with the old woman's other grandchildren. They all let him play without bothering him, pampering him as if trying to soothe my heart. My brother Fondling Yadgar and said:

– Your son will turn out to be even sharper than you! When my brother says: “Look at his chest, it's just like Hojimuqon's chest, look at his thigh!”, then the old woman says.

– Shut your eyes, my child, don't say that — a child is even more delicate than a flower.” My sister-in-law joined in:

– He resembles you as two peas in a pod! Not a single trait is different. My goodness, can a child really resemble his father this much?” I smiled quietly to myself.

There can't be any more love for family?

But I had to leave. My brother and my friends saw me off

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10. **Bugirsok** is a traditional fried dough food, typically made from flour, eggs, milk, and butter, shaped into small balls or ovals and deep-fried until golden brown.

11. **Patir** is a type of traditional Uzbek flatbread, usually round and thick, often baked in a tandoor (clay oven).

12. **Chuzma** is a traditional fried dough made like flatbread deep-fried until half crispy and golden.

13. **Chalpak** – a traditional Uzbek baked dough dish made from simple ingredients like flour, water, salt, and sometimes yeast. It is typically a round, flatbread that can be plain or decorated with patterns before baking. Chalpak is known for its soft texture and slightly crispy crust and is commonly served as a staple bread alongside meals in Uzbekistan. It holds cultural significance and is often prepared for special occasions and everyday consumption.

to the station. My brother held Yodgor in his arms. They all wished me success. They ask me to let them know whether I arrived safely and how I performed in the exam. I asked them to write a letter as well.

My brother, especially kind that day, said:

– If you need anything, write a letter at once. As a student, you might face difficulties, but I won’t hesitate to help you as much as I can. And don’t worry about the old women.” I looked out of the train window. Yodgor longs for me to take him I took him in my arms. The final boarding bell had already rung. I kissed both his cheeks, then returned him to my brother. Yodgar began to cry. The train started to move and left. I felt a strange, new emotion stir inside me that I had never experienced before —a kind of bittersweet ache that shook my whole body. Unbidden tears welled in my eyes.

Goodbye... goodbye...

The train rolled forward. My heart pounded with the thoughts: “How can I pass the exam?” Testing myself, I silently repeat the exercises that I have learned recently.

We passed the endless steppes of Kazakhstan, crossed the Orenburg border, and entered Samara province—lush green forests, boundless wheat fields, and massive factories puffing smoke toward the sky. I had never taken such a long journey before. Could our homeland really be this vast?

Yes, all of these are indivisible parts of our great socialist Homeland. And I am also one of the sons of this Homeland... I’m bursting with joy. I hum the songs I learned in the division, just loud enough to hear myself.

A Kazakh student from the Moscow Aviation school was traveling with me. He had come to Kizil Orda during his work leave. He began to speak of the vastness, greatness,

and prosperity of our homeland.

– Comrade,” he said, “you’re a red soldier. If you were a red aviator like me, you’d see just how vast our homeland truly is—from the Pacific Ocean to the Black Sea, from the North Pole to the Afghan border—it’s all our blessed land. Whatever don’t we have? We’ve got everything! If you get on a plane and fly far away, you will clearly see the beautiful cities of our Motherland, its velvet gardens, lush green forests, cotton fields, Donbass, the Urals, and Siberia — and then you will truly understand!

This student turned out to be a very open-hearted guy — he would often talk about his life, how his studies were going, and other things. He even started to talk me out of becoming a doctor and encouraged me to apply to aviation school instead. I replied: “True, aviation is a fascinating science, but I’m more passionate about becoming a doctor. Besides, I made a promise — to my commander and before five hundred comrades — that I would become a doctor.” I patted his shoulder and said: “Hey, comrade, we’re still young. What’s stopping us from completing not just one, but two faculties by the time we’re thirty? If I study seriously for four years, I’ll be a doctor. Do you think studying for another four years in a different faculty, like aviation engineering, would be too hard for you and me?

The four days we spent together were full of laughter and warmth. We spoke to each other like lifelong brothers. He gave me his address before we parted. Writing a letter to his address, I decided to inform him of my own address. We parted ways with him in Moscow.

As we approached Leningrad, my heart was fluttering like a young pigeon. After crossing a few denser, long forests, the city of Leningrad also began to appear.

Finally, after all the waiting and tension, our train arrived and stopped. Carrying my luggage, I got off the carriage. According to the address in my hand, I searched for and found the military academy. They welcomed me very warmly there. I started to get acquainted with students like myself, who had come from various parts of our great Motherland to prepare for the exam.

The exam days arrived. Things turned out just as I had been fearing. Although I passed the exams in all the major subjects with “excellent” and “good” grades, my weakness in the Russian language was clearly noticeable. However, the examination commission, considering the main facts stated in my biography, accepted me into the first course of the medical faculty under the military academy, with the condition that I would fully master the Russian language within the first year. My joy was overwhelming.

Now, the lessons have already begun. I cannot recall a sweeter, more delightful moment in my life than the first hour of lessons at the military academy. Comrades, just think about it: only two and a half years ago, I was an ignorant, rustic boy wandering the garden streets, singing loudly, and today I am sitting and listening to lectures by professors at the medical faculty of a military academy!

The lessons are becoming increasingly difficult and intense day by day. I don’t even have time to continue writing in the diary that I had started a year before. Nor can I reply to many of the letters arriving from Tashkent.

Indeed, now more than ever, patience, contentment, diligence, and perseverance are needed.

In my free time, I try to dedicate myself more to learning Russian. Since many students in our dormitory are from various nationalities, there are quite a few, like me, who are

not yet fluent in Russian. We help each other. However, I try to spend most of my free time in conversation with Russian students. I can understand all the lectures quite well now, and I no longer struggle much with speaking either. However, I still make many spelling mistakes in writing.

I passed the midterm exam successfully. During the fourteen-day winter break that comes after the exam period, I replied to several letters that had not yet been answered. Among these letters, the one that surprised me the most was from my aunt’s daughter, Saodat. I became astonished. What could have compelled her to write this letter? I had heard that our mothers had arranged for us to be engaged to each other, which is true, but after I brought Yadgar home, my aunt decided not to marry her daughter to me. I know this too. Until now, Saodat and I have never met face to face to talk about marriage or any plans for the future. So how does she now have the courage to write to me? True, at the time we were engaged, she was very young. She was only thirteen when I brought Yadgar home. Now she is sixteen years old. She could be considered to have come of age. So, what kind of letter is this? Could it be that she loves me? As for me, I look at her with a calm and indifferent attitude. I have not even asked my heart if it loves her.

Saodat wrote the following:

“Hello, *Jura Aka*<sup>14</sup>!”

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14. **Aka** literally means “elder brother” in Uzbek culture, but it is also widely used as a respectful and affectionate form of address for older men, even if they are not relatives. When someone says “Jura aka” or “Anvar aka” the term “aka” conveys respect, warmth, and recognition of seniority or experience. It reflects cultural values that emphasize politeness, familiar closeness and social hierarchy. Similar to using “Mr.” in English, but with a more personal and respectful tone.

I wish you success in your studies. I'm interested in knowing how your exam went, how your studies are going, and how your health is. I have some news for you: As you know, after finishing primary school, my parents did not allow me to continue my education and kept me at home. This year, for some reasons – perhaps they felt sorry for me, or maybe they agreed to my friends' requests—they finally allowed me to study again.

I took the entrance exam for the first-year course at the Pedagogical Technical School and was admitted. I am currently studying there. Even though the lessons are very difficult (I hope this doesn't sound like I'm boasting), I am getting 'excellent' marks in many subjects.

The other day, I went to visit your family to ask if there was any news from you. Your son Yadgar was playing around, looking quite chubby and adorable. I picked him up and held him close, and played with him for quite a while. If you could spare a moment of your precious time to write me even a short letter, I would be over the moon.

With respect: Saodat.

Now, how should I reply to this letter?

Saodat herself is not a bad girl. It's good that she has applied for studying again. This time, I decided to test her a little. Should I ask for her picture? No, that would be too much — it might scare her off.

I decided instead to ask her for a duppi (a traditional cap). I wrote a letter

“Saodat!

Many greetings from me. I'm fine and I hope you're staying healthy too. I was so glad to hear that you've been



accepted to Pedagogical Technical School. Every girl who wishes to be happy in the future must get an education. If you ask about me: I passed my exam well. I am keeping up with my classes (not to boast) just fine.

Saodat! I don't know if you will have time, but if you could go to our house and ask your aunt, if possible, to sew me a duppi, it would make me happy. Sometimes, seeing students in national dress during holidays makes me wish to wear something traditional too. I also would like to wear a duppi from time to time.

Say hello to everyone from me!

With respect, Jura.”

I couldn't allow myself to indulge in any further thoughts. After all, I was just a first-year student. If I started thinking about Saodat and others now, it might interfere with my studies.

The classes started again. And once again, that same solemn life. getting up early in the morning and living the student life until one o'clock at night.

The month May has come. All the students are working day and night preparing for the final exams. I am doing the same.

During one of those serious days, I received a small package in the mail. I opened it and found several layers of fabric tied together with silk. When I slowly opened the paper, I saw a single green silk duppi inside, and from within it, a small silk handkerchief slipped out. On one corner of the silk handkerchief, there was a beautifully embroidered image of a butterfly and a red flower bud, delicately crafted

from threads of various silks. Inside it, there was a tiny letter, folded just like the paper used to wrap aspirin powder. I opened and read the letter. Again, it was from Saodat:

*“Dear Jura Aka!*

*Endless greetings.*

*I’m sorry I couldn’t send what you had asked from my aunt on time. I was a little upset with you. But you must know this: sewing a duppi is young people’s work. I thought it would be shameful to let my poor aunt, in her old age, set everything aside just to sew a duppi for you — so I decided to make it myself. As you know, I am also a student. Because of how intense the studies are, I couldn’t find time to finish sewing quickly. The holidays are approaching. The other day, I went to your family’s home again and said, ‘I am going to write a letter to Jura Aka — do you have any message you want to add?’ Your mother was very happy. Especially, your son Yadgar seems to miss you very much. I tried to comfort him by saying, “Your father will come home during the holidays.”*

*By the way, I have another piece of news for you: I have recently been accepted into the Komsomol (Young Communist League). Greetings from everyone.*

*Awaiting your letter, Saodat.”*

The matter became somewhat clearer to me. Especially the flower bud and butterfly embroidered on the handkerchief seemed to hint at something deeper. It felt as though they were trying to tell me something.

I wondered, could it be that Saodat really loves me? As for myself?

No, I still hadn't felt anything in my heart. It would be better to forget about such thoughts for now. But at the same time, it wouldn't be right to break a girl's heart either. In any case, I decided to write her a reply. In return for the duppi, I could also send her a gift. But then again, if I sent something, it might seem like I was giving her a hidden message. Better not to send anything. I decided to just write a letter — that would be enough.

I wrote a letter. It was simple, just like before — a letter from a brother to a sister. I thanked her for the duppi. I explained that I wouldn't be able to come home during the holidays this year. I said that I missed my family members, especially Yadgar. At the end, I asked her to keep writing to me more often.

The exam days arrived. My Russian had improved somewhat. But then another problem appeared. I will not hide it now — I will say it openly. I couldn't be satisfied with my Anatomy exam results. Therefore, I decided not to go to Tashkent during the holidays and instead went to the academy's *dacha* (summer house) to prepare with the help of my friends.

But the truth is, I missed Yadgar very much. Unexpectedly, at the end of June, I received a 100 sum transfer from my brother. In the letter that came with the transfer, my brother seemed to be apologizing to me. Sorry," he said, "I have a lot of kids, so I couldn't send more. Anyway, student life is like that — whatever you get, it's better than nothing, and even a little can sometimes feel like a lot." Even your aunts have given up their fight—they're now saying, "We have no daughter to give to an outsider; Saodat belongs to Jura". So, you can rest easy on that front too," he said. You can be

reassured about this matter.” In short, family matters...

So, Saodat’s *duppi*, handkerchief, and the butterfly and flower embroidery were not just trivial things. The situation became clear to me. It is good that I haven’t gone on holiday this year. No matter what, I might get emotionally attached — maybe because of youth, manhood, or some other reason. No, however hard it might be, even though Saodat loves me and I might love her, I can endure it. I will endure until I finish my studies.

During my time at the summer house, I had a lot of free time since my only exam left was anatomy. So, I spent some of my free time wandering around the city sightseeing. The 100 sum I got from my brother was more than enough, so I bought some clothes for Yadgar and sent them along with a large recent photo of me to the family.

A month later, after sending the package and my photo to Yadgar, I received a letter from Saodat. Saodat must have finally gathered her courage this time — the letter was full of subtle jabs and sarcasm.” She wrote:

*“Dearest Jura Aka!*

*My aunt decorated the edges of the photo you sent for Yadgor with flowers and hung it on the wall at home. Whenever Yodgor reaches out crying ‘Daddy’ each day, they show him the photo. After gazing at it for a moment, as if to satisfy his longing, they gently put it away again.*

*When I asked, ‘Come on, Yodgor, let me see your father’s photo too,’ but with his sweet little voice he said, ‘Please don’t touch it — this is my daddy,’ and didn’t allow me to touch it. But then when I said, ‘Well, if that’s your daddy, then he’s my Jura Aka, isn’t he?’, he replied, ‘Okay, sure,’ and*

*handed it to me. Then, as I looked at your picture, I thought: It seems the photographer took only one copy of this photo, thinking he might give it to some of your acquaintances, and didn't take more copies. If only you had sent us one too — we would have cherished it even more than you do. So I said to myself, 'If you won't send one, then I will,' and sent you a photo of me together with Yodgor.*

*Please, don't be upset about the photographer.*

*As they say, "What you see is what you get" — the photographer captured the real image of us.*

*By the way, did the duppi suit well on your head?*

*Jura Aka, if it's not too much trouble, could you send me a woolen beret<sup>15</sup>? It's become quite fashionable for girls in Tashkent to wear berets nowadays.*

*Endless greetings from me, Missing you,*

*Saodat.*

*By the way, let the people in Tashkent not find out that I sent you a photo.*

Her letter, especially the photo, set my heart on fire. Amazing — is this really our Saodat? The girl seems to have grown up quite a bit! Now I truly believe that a photo is only half a meeting. Her black eyes seemed to call me to a contest of love, and her lips, half-smiling, seemed to be saying something. Her clear, unblemished face, with disheveled

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15. A beret (from the Russian word *беремка*, derived from French *béret*) is a type of soft, round, flat-crowned cap, traditionally made of wool, felt, or knit fabric. It is worn tilted to one side and has no brim. In Central Asia and post-Soviet countries, the term *beretka* is commonly used to refer to this stylish, often feminine headwear, frequently worn by women as part of both casual and formal outfits.

hair falling over it, felt like it was ready to tie my heart in chains.

Believe me, Saodat, believe me! I love you, and I swear I will never let a single tear hang from those dark, curly eyelashes of yours for as long as I live.

The girl, with all her grace, was calling me to love.

Real love for Saodat has started to grow in me. However, with the academic year approaching, I knew that getting involved in love conflicts could be risky and distracting for my studies. Therefore, I decided to write Saodat the last letter of this semester. Along with it, I planned to send the beret she had asked for. I went to the city and bought a stylish beret. In my letter, I gave her subtle hints of my love and affection. In the letter, along with the photo, I explained that since my studies are approaching, I have very little time and might not be able to write again soon. I asked her to keep in touch with both Yadgar and the old woman. This marked the end of the first chapter of our newly started “romance.” A joyful chapter of the future — a ‘holiday’ has been granted until the next year’s vacation period.

Since I couldn’t go during the holidays, the old woman seemed a bit upset. She also mentioned that my son had fallen ill. I had heard that Qumri, who had entered the textile factory’s Vocational school, had been provided with a dorm and scholarship. As for Abdugani, since he hadn’t finished elementary school yet, he was still with the old woman. In a letter from my elder brother, he wrote: ‘You don’t need to worry about old woman, Abdugani, or Yadgar anymore. I’m keeping track of their welfare. There are no difficulties on this side.’ This news put me at ease, and I was able to focus on my studies without any unnecessary worries. Indeed, I was able to maintain excellent results in my second year of

university, and the issues I had faced in Russian last year were no longer a problem. I had even managed to catch up on anatomy. As a result, I passed most of my exams with high marks, and I planned to spend my holiday in Tashkent.

The year passed by without any major events in my life to write down in diary. So, life seemed to flow smoothly, like a steady stream, with work and studies filling my time. Although I had written to the family about my plans to go to Tashkent for the holidays, I hadn't specified the exact time or date. I didn't want to openly announce it because I knew that if I sent a letter or telegram, Saodat would probably come to meet me. The thought of meeting her for the first time in front of our relatives made me feel uncomfortable. Honestly, it would have been awkward for me. So, I decided to buy small, inexpensive gifts for the old woman, Qumri, Abdigani, Yodgor, and Saodat, using the extra money I had saved from my scholarship. In mid-July, I left for Tashkent.

Unexpectedly, when I arrived early in the morning and walked into the house, the old woman was completely surprised. The poor woman rushed down from the veranda to the corridor with open arms, threw herself at me, and hugged me tightly around the neck. She began to cry out of joy as we greeted. She started kissing my face, almost unable to speak, her words coming out in a jumble. She couldn't say what she wanted. Despite her old age, she was going to carry my suitcase and take it to the porch. I didn't allow her to do that, and I carried the suitcase myself. We sat down and exchanged pleasantries. My eyes kept wandering around, but I couldn't see Yadgar anywhere.

— “So, where's Yadgar, Mom?”

— “Oh, by the way, I'll bring him out right now. He's growing up, becoming a big boy, and goes to kindergarten

now. In the morning, he gets up right at dawn, and if possible, he runs off to kindergarten without even drinking his tea. I always shout after him, ‘Hey, make sure nothing runs over you on the street, don’t get lost!’ I end up following him around the neighborhood. That’s why every morning Abdugani takes him to kindergarten when he is going to school.

He himself brings him back after school.”

— “Stop it, old woman, I’ll bring him back myself!” I said, but she didn’t listen and went out. About ten minutes later, she returned holding Yadgar’s hand. He was wearing a blue robe given by the kindergarten. Under his arm was a toy bus, rattling as he walked. As soon as he saw me on the porch, without hesitation, he threw the toy on the ground and ran up to me, shouting “Dad!” and jumped into my arms. I hugged him, kissed his face, and admired how cheerful and lively he had become, always curious about everything. In an instant, he forgot that I had just arrived and had missed him and started hailing questions at me:

— Dad, what is this?

— It’s a button, my boy, a button.

— Why does it have a star?

— “The soldiers have buttons like this.”

What is a soldier, Dad?

Do you know the Red Army, son?”

— We also play Red Army at kindergarten. I play the role of *Budyonny*<sup>16</sup>.”

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16. **Budyonny** (Semyon Mikhailovich) was a prominent Soviet military commander, one of the first five Marshals of the Soviet Union. He was famous for his role during the Russian Civil War as a commander of the Red Cavalry, where his leadership helped secure victories for the Bolsheviks. Budyonny was known for his cavalry skills and toughness, earning a legendary reputation.



— Yes, exactly. The Red Army wears buttons like that.  
Suddenly, he forgot the question and moved on to a new one:

— When did you come?

— I just arrived, son.

— How did you get here?

I came by train; do you know what a train is?

Sharip's father came by airplane.

The old woman scolds Yadgar:

— You've become quite a spoiled brat, haven't you? I also want to speak with him.

He doesn't listen to the old woman.

— Dad, Dad, I can sing a song!

— Oh, really? Try singing then.

Without hesitation, he stood up from my lap and began to sing:

White gold fields are in our hands!

The Party leads us, firm where it stands.

No foe can hunt in our lakes; we guard our lands!

To make the USSR rich in cotton,

The Party lights our path - it lifts the gloom!

— That's it, we know it.

— Well, fine, you're growing up to be a good boy!

— Won't you leave again?

— No, I won't leave anymore.

— See you then, I'll go to my kindergarten.

As he ran off, the old woman called after him:

— Be careful, walk on the side of the way. If a bus comes, step aside so it doesn't run over you, my dear!

I talked about the past events with the old woman. As we talked, the old woman added:

— Saodat is such a thoughtful girl. She calls me every other day, asking how I am.

For some reason, she hasn't come for the past three days. I was there, alert to every noise, listening for that knock—wondering if she might be the one coming. My goodness, she is a jack of all trades. In just a few minutes, she completed all my house chores. The other day, she came and said, 'Auntie, shall I wash your laundry for you? I told her, 'You've done so much already, you should rest, but if you can, one day you'll do the washing.' Above all, it's Yadgar she loves the most — she's constantly fussing over him, practically wearing herself out for his sake.

Yadgar has also grown quite attached to her. If she doesn't come for two days, he says, 'Sister hasn't come yet,' and waits for her to return from school."

A few people had seen me arriving

I had exchanged greetings with them. Besides that, the news about my arrival spread through the whole neighborhood and the village in no time — and in less than an hour, the house was filled with relatives. There were many more people to meet, and we kept talking and catching up and we chatted about old times. To be honest, I had grown somewhat distant from my family. Although these social rituals were meant to be warm, they made me uncomfortable. For some reason, I found myself looking towards the door, as if I were searching for someone among the relatives who had arrived. I knew no one special was coming. Come on, why should I keep it hidden: I long for Saodat ... On one hand, I was glad she hadn't arrived yet.

You might wonder why — with so many people and relatives around, how could I ever meet her, in any way at all? A little smile, a brief two-minute exchange of glances, a short greeting to ask how she's doing — and that's all...

I spent the whole day watching the comings and goings of people. Even Abdugani has grown into quite a capable young man. He is now in the fifth grade. I managed to pull him aside from the guests and the old woman for a chat.

— Did you tell your sister Saodat that I've arrived?

While you were busy with the guests, my mother insisted that I go and inform her.

I went and informed her.

— Was Saodat at home?

— No, she was at school. I told my aunt, though.

— And what about your brother-in-law?

— My brother-in-law was at home.

Just as our conversation was about to end, my aunt walked in carrying a basket, all hot and sweaty. She immediately greeted me loudly:

— Oh, my dear, how can I be of help to you?

My aunt was very warm with me, hugging me tightly. She kissed my forehead. They both took me in between them and, from here and there, started talking about what I had seen and experienced. I carried myself with a strong sense of pride, responding to the questions shortly yet with solemn confidence. However, in the middle of our chat, I was secretly hoping someone would bring up Saodat's name. At the very least, hearing her name would bring me some comfort. Having finished his work, my brother also arrived. While we were having a brief conversation, I heard the voices of some young

men calling me from outside. Concluding my chat with the family, I had to go out to meet my friends. They were Obid, Mansur, Yuldosh who had grown up together since youth, and other young lads from the neighborhood. We exchanged greetings, and Obid invited me over to his home. We sat down and talked about old times, catching up on everything. While we were talking, Obid gave me a teasing look and started talking about Saodat. I was surprised that my love for Saodat — still just a bud, not yet in full bloom — had already become the talk of the town. It must have been because of my “honest service” — my grandmother’s or my aunt’s innate tendency to gossip. Besides, since Obid was the director of the women’s technical college, it was easy for him to get information about Saodat. Our conversation lasted until late evening. After bidding farewell to my friends, I returned to the yard and, exhausted, sank into a deep sleep, feeling the warmth of a family embrace — the kind of warmth I hadn’t experienced in two years.

Saodat still hadn’t come the next morning. My heart was uneasy, and I began to wonder if she might have been upset by the letter I sent — the one suggesting we keep our communication more sporadic. If she did come, I was planning to show a little resentment.

Then I tried to comfort myself, thinking maybe she was waiting for the coming and going to quiet down, or perhaps she felt too shy to come see me while her mother was still here

After breakfast, my aunt left. Since it seemed no one else was coming, not even a single visitor, I decided to take a short walk around the city. Yet my heart yearned, softly whispering, Saodat hasn’t come... still, she hasn’t come.

The city of Tashkent had changed a lot. New buildings, new streets, and even the way people treated each other had changed a great deal since I last saw them. I spent time strolling and observing, completely unaware that it had already become two or three o'clock. I had to return home soon. I came back carrying ten or fifteen cucumbers and two melons. Drinking the soup my grandmother had prepared, I was reading the newspapers. I found my eyes glued to the page, though my mind kept drifting to Saodat. Every time I heard a sound at the door, I'd look, hoping it would be her. Around five or six o'clock, my heart was racing with anticipation, and the long-awaited "guest" finally arrived. She is not Saodat — the one I still carry in my mind's eye, wearing a ruched atlas (satin) dress. Instead, it was a girl in a well-tailored dress, holding a small handbag, wearing the beret I had sent her, with her hair neatly styled — an average-looking European girl. She entered the room, biting her lower lip in a shy manner, looking quite embarrassed.

Her face was swollen—whether from the heat after a long journey or from embarrassment, I couldn't tell, her lips, the tip of her nose, and her forehead were covered with a fine sheen of sweat. She seemed to be trying to hide her eyes under the pretext of wiping the sweat away. I stood up abruptly. Thrusting out my chest with a military-like posture, I stepped forward to face her. I shook her hand firmly, greeting her with a smile that was hiding behind my eyes. She became very shy. At that moment, it seemed like she was about to fly away like a swallow. She gently withdrew her hand from mine and started exchanging greetings with the old woman. The old woman quickly seated him, making it seem as though she had just prepared a fresh table setting.

The two of us sat facing each other at the low dining table. The old woman had intended to serve tea and some bread but Saodat, half rising from her seat, said:

— Don't trouble yourself, aunt, let me pour the tea. The old woman, with affection, replied:

— No, let your aunt take care of it. You're the guest now, my child! When you're well, you can serve the tea yourself.

Something subtle seemed to pass between us at my grandmother's simple words. Saodat glanced at me from the corner of her eye. I did the same. In a brief moment, our gazes met over the crystal sugar on the table. We exchanged a barely noticeable smile. Saodat looked down.

She had become a perceptive young woman, able to find traces of love in even the subtlest of gestures. Everything around me seemed to smile at me. Even the air in the yard seemed filled with the scent of unmarried girls' pillows. Saodat sat looking down at the floor, gently tapping a small sugar cube against the edge of the tray. This situation seemed to have tied my tongue as well.

Finally, the old woman broke the short time silence:

— “You two sit and talk for a while, my children. I'll go check on the kitchen.”

Please, auntie, there's no need for anything. Don't trouble yourself—I'll leave now. The old woman:

— Why would you leave? Sit and chat with your brother Jura for a while. What, do you think I would slaughter a sheep for you?” Ot is our ordinary meal that we always have, my child, - she said.

— That's true, said Saodat, “When I see you working in the kitchen, I really feel sorry for you, aunt.

I got involved too:

— Mom, if that’s the case, you get the ingredients ready, I haven’t cooked *palov*<sup>17</sup> in quite a while myself.

— Come on,— said Saodat,— don’t bother with pots and pans dressed like that, really, what about me?

— You’ll burn it.

— Even if I do, I won’t burn it the way you would.

We glanced at each other again. The conversation about the palov gave us an excuse to start a new topic. Using the palov as an excuse, the old woman left us alone and went to the kitchen. I searched for a topic to continue our interrupted conversation.

— What’s this with you carrying a briefcase during the holiday? When I sent Abdugani, he said you were at school. Has your school year not finished yet?

— The lessons have already finished. They insisted on appointing me as the organizer of the women’s club. I have never done such things in my life before. It turned out that bringing women together and uniting them was quite a difficult task.

Saodat gave me another sarcastic look.

You seem to turn every conversation in a different direction. We used to hear that people from Leningrad are very skilled in dealing with people.

It looks like you’ve been taught quite a bit. In response, I took out the handkerchief that Saodat herself had sewn for me from my pocket. I pretended to wipe my eyes with it, as if to indicate, “I still carry it with me.” Although Saodat

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17. **Palov** (also spelled *plov*, *pilaf*, or *osh*) is a traditional Central Asian rice dish, especially popular in Uzbekistan, where it is considered the national dish.

recognized it, she pretended not to.

At that moment, Yadgar, playing outside, ran into the room, pulling his cart along. He went straight for Saodat, leaving me behind. The child was extremely happy:

— Sister, when did you come? Why didn't you come tomorrow?" (meaning "yesterday?") Saodat was also hugging Yodgor and affectionately pampering him. As I watched their interaction, I was lost in thoughts about the future. Is this love real for the child? Will it last like this even after we get married? Whenever Yodgor's past is revealed, I wonder how Saodat will react and what she will say. I thought over those stories from that time, even if only briefly, and wanted to compare Yodgor's unfaithful mother and Saodat to each other in terms of their qualities. Saodat is much sharper and more intelligent than that unfaithful woman. What a coincidence, the abandoned child of one woman is in the loving embrace of a beautiful girl...

Seeing even a hint of that silent pensiveness on my face, Saodat suddenly turned her kindness into harshness. In a sarcastic tone:

— Jura Aka, — she said, — you're daydreaming too much... That's how the world is—it separates people from each other at the most unexpected times. Don't be upset.

I was startled, gathering all my thoughts to one side, and smiled a little. I tried to change the subject. I tried to change the topic. Looking into her eyes with gentle admiration, I said: — Saodat, how you are — so wonderfully kind.

Saodat seemed startled.

— Wow, how have you suddenly become very eager to praise? — I was taken aback, and then she said to Yadgar, — Yadgar, are you listening to what your father is saying?!



There was quite a lot that could be said under the pretext of Yadgar. But the old woman busy in the kitchen, wanting to keep even Yodgor from disturbing us, called him over with a trick:

—Yadgar, hey Yadgar, my son, look this way, I'm making you some corn kebab,— she called him, coaxing him away.

Our conversation had taken a lighter turn, much more open than before—just enough that more delicate matters could now be broached with care.

— Saodat, I said gently, are you free this evening?

And what if I am?

I thought we might stroll through the parks of Tashkent.

With you? That sounds... strange.

Well, what are you shy about? You're a grown girl, aren't you?

— You know how my father is. If he happened to see us—well, you can imagine the scandal!

You're quite strange. If not today, then another time we'll anyway walk together.

Saodat looked at me abruptly, then with a bit of coyness said:

— Really, who told you that?

— Your eyes did.

Jura aka, You're really acting up. I'll inform my aunt about you?

— What would your aunt do? She'd actually be happy. Come on, don't change the subject — are you free this evening?

Yes, I will. But still—let's not stir up gossip. I'd be

embarrassed.

I coaxed her gently, paying no mind to her playful resistance, until she agreed.

“So, the first chapter of the meeting, the second part of the ‘novel’ that began in Leningrad, also turned out to be a success.

The old woman came in, serving the palov. We began to eat sitting together. The old woman was trying to steer the conversation elsewhere by pretending to be simple:

— Juravoy, my dear child, do you like the palov cooked by old women? We tend to make it soggy and soft, just like ourselves. If Saodat had prepared, it would’ve been like silk ribbon — just perfect.

— Oh no, Auntie,” Saodat replied modestly, “I can’t cook like this. I’m good at frying carrots and onions, sure — but I never get the salt right.

Then it was my turn:

— I can make a delicious palov too — just as long as someone else lights the fire for me.

— Oh, my child,” said the old woman, “It is four years, you still can’t cook a proper pilaf with all the ingredients?

At these words, Saodat blushed and looked down. I thought to myself, ‘Alas, the old woman got me — she just used an old trick. In order to change the subject again the old woman began to scold Yadgar, who was sitting there smearing food all over his mouth and nose with all five fingers:

— My dear child, eat without spilling. Take your food like this, pinch it properly!

The old woman’s sarcasm passed almost unnoticed.

After the meal, the old woman picked up the dish and went to the kitchen. Saodat got up, intending to leave. I had firmly made her promise to go to the park in the evening. Leaving the yard together felt a touch too bold — for both of us. That’s why we decided to meet at the tram stop.

Saodat and I often spend time together. The fact that we went to the park together two or three times in just one month had already been enough for everyone to start catching on. Even though Saodat’s friends had teased her once or twice, it eventually became something normal in their eyes, and no one talked about it anymore. Word about how often Saodat and I were together eventually reached her father’s ear. He met with my older brother and said, “It’s good that what is bound to happen will happen. A girl’s reputation is very delicate. It would’ve been better if Juravoy should take an academic leave for a year and go ahead with the wedding — I’m so tired of people constantly asking, “When’s the wedding?” My elder brother replied, “Alright, I’ll talk to him. I asked my brother to explain, with all due tact and reason, that I had no intention of marrying until I had completed my studies. There were still things I needed to finish, and I hoped they would understand. One day Saodat came to me and said:

— Jura aka, my father sends you his regards. He says you’ll be coming to our house this Sunday evening with a few friends. Since there’s no one else to run errands, it’s poor me who’s been sent to deliver the message.”

I laughed: “Ah, so we’re already sharing post-wedding feasts before the wedding, are we?”

— You and your teasing,” she said, half-laughing. “I should say what I need and be off before you make another

joke.

When the appointed day came, I brought along my friend Obid, who was a department head at our technical school. The feast, with all its rich food and drink, was excellent. But Saodat didn't come out of the kitchen. My brother-in-law, that is, Saodat's father, was serving us himself. My brother-in-law was feeling quite relaxed this time and called my aunt:

— *Saodat! Saodat*<sup>18</sup>! Come here, don't run away from Mulla Obid. Are you going to run away from our daughter's teacher too? Call your Saodat as well — He's her teacher whom she sees every day! Should I be the one serving while you are all at home? Juravoy is one of us!

Obid joked:

Umar aka, why won't you go out to the gardens with your wife!

We laughed.

— Hey, my little brother," my brother-in-law said, "our time has passed now. Now it's your turn — it suits you, young ones, to walk in the gardens.

It seemed that her father's gesture was exactly what Saodat had been waiting for. After his words, she brought a few things to the hallway and began serving while remaining partially out of sight. As for me, I tried not to look toward the door as much as possible. I tried to maintain my composure. We chatted here and there for quite a while.

Before we left, my aunt placed the second pair of the quilted duppi sent to Leningrad on my head.

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18. In old Uzbek culture husbands called their wife with their eldest child's name. That's why, here, Saodat's father calls his wife with his eldest daughter's name.

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Such a sweet life is passing by so quickly. Soon I will return to Leningrad. I don't know how the hours spent with Saodat have passed so quickly. When Saodat saw that I was beginning to prepare to leave, she said:

Don't go — or take me with you.

My departure date has become very certain.

I will leave around the 15th of August.

That's why tomorrow Saodat and I plan to go out for the last time. And there I want to get her true promise. Through Abdugani I sent a tiny letter to Saodat and received the reply "Okay." The next evening, she came to our courtyard. The old woman had prepared a little food and served it separately for us. After the meal, I quietly moved next to Saodat. I held her hand between my palms, looked into her eyes, and said:

— My dear Saodat," I said, "today or tomorrow I will go back to Leningrad. You will also start your studies, that's why I called you. I want to hear your honest thoughts about our life together.

What life? What do you mean?

— Come on, don't act naive. You know that I love you, and I know that you love me too.

Who told you that?..

Well, never mind. Tell me, what do you think about our life together?

Is there also a pedagogical technical school in Leningrad?

Yes, there is...

If I go, would they accept me?

They won't accept you, you don't know Russian.

Won't you teach me?

Is it even possible to teach you anything?..

A military man shouldn't speak like that — instead, give me a command!

— Okay, fine, I'll give you a command: Get ready! In two years, we will have our wedding. I will finish my studies and come back. You also must finish your studies. For a bright life, for a true life, to become parents of good children — forward march!

Saodat, forgetting even to be shy about the old woman overhearing, couldn't stop herself and burst into loud laughter... The other part of our conversation turned serious. Saodat stood still wanting to know who Yadgar's mother was and to hear the story about it. I promised her to tell the whole story of Yadgar after the wedding.

Our promise was settled. I promised to become the best doctor, and she promised to become the best teacher.

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I stayed in Leningrad for another two years. I didn't find it suitable to come to Tashkent during the mid-year vacation, especially since the last year's studies had become very difficult. Like the saying "Chasing two rabbits, you catch neither," if I spent even a little of this precious time on love quarrels, it could disturb my studies. Since Saodat and I had made a promise, I didn't have to worry about this at all.

Despite that, she writes to me regularly, and I reply to her occasionally. Similarly, the letters with the family affairs were on normal level: they say "we miss you," "Your son is aching with longing for you." the old woman says "I am sick," and such similar words...

I am preparing very intensely for the final year exam. Since much of our work is practical experience, most of the time is spent in clinics. Since I aspire to specialize in internal medicine, I have a strong interest in internal diseases.

The exam time has come. Professors found my knowledge good in almost all subjects. According to the advice of the academy leaders, I need to stay in Leningrad for one more year to complete my diploma work. But I want to ask to defend my diploma in Tashkent. Since this part is optional, they gave me permission. Having taken my necessary documents, saying goodbye to my teachers, professors and friends, I transferred my military registration to Tashkent. With that, I said goodbye to the honorable city of Leningrad, which held me in its arms for four years, nurtured me, and turned me from a simple red soldier into a highly educated military doctor.

I am extremely happy, extremely joyful. On the way, I reflect on everything that has happened so far—especially over the past six or seven years of my life.

As we approach Tashkent, my heart beats faster. As usual, I haven't sent a telegram to my family about when I will arrive. Only Saodat knows when I will arrive.

The train gradually slowed down and stopped at Tashkent station. Putting my coat on my wrist, holding my suitcase in my hand, I look out the carriage window at the platform.

People, wives, children — the greeters run along the carriage. Looking in the windows, they shout out names of some people. Among them, I search for Saodat. There she is! Saodat, whom I longed for with a pounding heart! She is looking for someone. When she came beside our carriage

window, I tapped on the glass. She glanced up with a flush:

— Jura aka! — She started running toward the door. I also got out of the compartment and walked into the corridor. She had already reached the gangway.

She did not hesitate at all. Without hesitation, she rushed at me...

It was as if both of us had come from Leningrad together, we entered our house through the door.

My arrival caused great joy in both houses — in our house and in Saodat's family home as well. My mother, knowing that my studies were finished, was overjoyed to the point she seemed unable to contain herself. The hope of the "youngest daughter-in-law," which for years had remained just a dream, was finally within reach. I could hear that both houses were busily preparing for the upcoming wedding. Since I had no reason to refuse the wedding arrangement, I also gave my consent to it.

Yadgar, who had just turned six and lived two or three months into his seventh year, had become quite sharp. Someone had explained things to him. He came, hugged my knees, and said:

— Dad, will you bring me a *white mum*<sup>19</sup>? — he asked. I feel a pang of sadness at his words. Poor Yadgar, I say, "Someday you'll realize I'm not your real father — you are the child of some unfaithful but beautiful woman, abandoned, and a harsh, unfamiliar, reckless man that I don't know..." I say this, yet I try to console myself and strengthen my confidence. No, Yadgar — he is absolutely my son, and Saodat's first child, I say, trying to bring him

19. **A white mum** – a pure and kind mother figure, a mother whose love is unstained and selfless.



into the conversation:

— What other mother could I give you, my son? My grandmother — she is mother to both you and me, as well as to your brother Abdugani and your sister Qumri. He leans against me affectionately and playfully says:

— But she's my grandmother — you should bring me Sister Saodat instead! I will make her my pure white mother myself...

— Oh, my little silly son, who told you that? Okay, okay, I'll bring her — I say laughing.

A summer as warm as a loving embrace, black grapes ripened like the face of happiness, red-seeded melons sweet as love. On one of the hot days of July, Saodat and I, hand in hand, went to the registry office. This was my second visit to registry office. Many things here, even some ugly rules of life, seem familiar to me. It feels as if I came here just yesterday. Moreover, I quietly glance beside me, hoping this visit would not be like the first. No, this is my Saodat! My faithful Saodat! I have come with her for the promise of lifelong happiness.

They say everything in life has two sides like a scale; sweetness has bitterness, darkness has light, night has day, a thorn has a flower. I have endured its bitterness. I have been confused by its darkness. I stayed in darkness through the night. I suffered from its thorns. Now finally, all of this is over.

Now Saodat and I stand before the thick, hardbound registry book of registry office— opened like a window to our happiness — amidst smiling faces. A long and bright life path. This path is full of light, abundant with sweetness,

continuous daylight, and covered with flowers.

She tightly squeezed my hand and asked:

— What will my last name be? Please answer — you’re keeping the registry office waiting,” she said. I abruptly looked into her eyes, full of love and affection. All my past thoughts scattered like ashes meeting a storm:

— It’s your choice; if you want, you can take my last name<sup>20</sup>.

We left the registry office and headed towards the clothing store...

The military commissariat sent me to a distant border region. I was appointed as the doctor of the border guard detachment here.

After getting married, I was at home with Saodat for no more than three or four months.

Saodat still has one more year of study left. Therefore, I felt uneasy about bringing her along with me.

Since I have spent a large part of my life in military service, I don’t find it difficult here. But longing continues to have its effect. Before marriage, I had never experienced this feeling. I look at the starry sky on long nights. I see the moonlight playing on the small waves of the gently flowing Amu Darya river. Like a wide river, I want to open my arms and see Saodat in my waving chest. I climb the steep hills, and before my eyes, a vast border unfolds. On one side lies happiness and prosperity, the true home of humanity — the

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20. In Uzbek culture, when a girl and a boy are engaged and later get married, it is customary for the wife to take her husband’s surname. This tradition reflects the social norm that the family name is carried through the male line. A cultural practice in Uzbekistan in which, after marriage, the wife adopts her husband’s surname.

magnificent socialist homeland. On the other side, there is indulgence — the smoke from the black kettle rises, merging with the dark sky of dark lives. A country of poor people — a small part of the oppressed East — crushed under the iron heels of some feudals. I am deeply moved by the plight of the helpless!

Poor souls, it won't be long before the word "border" is erased from the pages of history.

A bright dawn awaits you too. Soon, you will break free from the shackles of your past and live a life of joy like ours...

In the sky, from north to south along the Milky Way, a caravan of cranes and geese flies by. As if they were predicting the swift fulfillment of my dreams, they flew by with a soft, 'hak-hak' call...

I return to my room again. Even though I have read Saodat's letters several times, I read them again. These letters seem to speak to me in her voice, and I kiss them gently, as if they were her lips.

All our border guards are built like tanks, and although I've been here for two or three months, I haven't come across single serious ill ones among them. Only the few who fall ill are mostly due to colds or sunstroke. Since there's little work at the military clinic, with the commanders' permission, I also work at the civilian clinic. A large part of my life here revolves around helping the collective farmers and city residents alike.

My reputation for kindness is well known, especially among the civilians. My knowledge of the local language is considered one of the main reasons for my success in treating their ailments. Just as I have a good reputation among the civilians, I am also well-respected among the

local organizations. I've made quite a few close friends and buddies. At weekends, we visit each other and spend time together cheerfully.

One day, one of my friends, a man who held a responsible position in our region, invited me to his home.

— Comrade doctor, — he said, — I have a patient who hasn't been getting better for quite some time; I've shown him to many doctors.” Each one gives different opinions, but none have been able to cure the patient. To be honest, the patient is my wife. I would be grateful if you could visit her and take a look.”

This young man looked a year or two older than me, had a clean heart, and was a very cheerful person. Especially among the friends I made from the district, he and I held our hearts very close to each other. Without going back on my word, I went to his house on the appointed day. After sitting and talking for a while in the guest room, he took me to the bedroom. In the farther part of the room, on a steel bed, a young wife — a patient — lay staring at the ceiling. As soon as she saw me, she tried to get up from the bed. To spare her any discomfort, I quickly suggested she remain lying down. Despite her pale complexion and her weakened state, the sharp traces of beauty in her face shone through. A woman in her mid-twenties. I examined her closely, with the precision of a doctor, I don't know what conclusion the other doctors reached, but in my opinion, the woman showed no serious illness other than acute nervousness. I shared my thoughts with my friend and suggested sending his wife on a trip to help her recover. As the conversation unfolded, I inquired about their family life, whether they had children. He sighed deeply, then replied:

— We don't have children. To be honest, part of this person's ailments stemmed from the fact that she had no child, he said. I pressed further, asking about the length of their marriage — whether they had children or if they had been unable to conceive. (Doctors sometimes find such personal inquiries useful, as they can shed light on a greater issue.) Perhaps he grew weary or frustrated with the probing, for he then said:

— Comrade Doctor, do you wish to know everything? Very well, let me tell you.

So, comrade doctor, about six or seven years ago, I was a very naïve young man and (pointing to his wife), she was just an ordinary Uzbek girl veiled in her paranja.

Now you see for yourself, you know: I studied at AACI (Association for the Automation and Computerization of Industry), became a party member, and started to look at things differently. I am no longer the same naïve youth I once was. The person I am today—the civilized, humane one—has nothing to do with the story I'm telling now. Studying she has become an activist, a person of principle. We have loved each other for five years, and despite times apart, we have always longed for one another, living in harmony and mutual care. The political party appointed me as the official responsible for this region. I have been working here for two years. Of course, none of this is of any interest to you. Here's where it gets interesting — listen closely, comrade doctor!

The story of our marriage is quite an interesting one. As I mentioned earlier, I was just a simple, rough-edged fellow. And she was the modest daughter of a devout Muslim family, veiled in virtue. What can I say — call it youthful pride or the arrogance of manhood — we fell in love with each other. I

swore I'd marry no one but her, and she promised to belong to no one but me. But her father would never consent to our marriage. Even so, we were inseparable, as if bound by love. For a while, we kept our love hidden. You see, comrade doctor, as I was just an unworldly, rough fellow — and she, the veiled beauty inside her paranja, was like a timid little rabbit, or as our elders say, “a sugar on paper” girl, we found ourselves at a loss about what to do next. Only the two of us and her mother knew this secret. What can we do? If this secret became known to anyone, her father wouldn't be able to hold his head up in public—it would be like death to him. For us, and especially for her, this would have been a terrible disgrace. The three of us, naive as we were, could do nothing but keep the secret as best we could and wait for the day she would give birth.

Oh, my friend, back then, forget about the hardships Mehri and I went through.

I feel like a scoundrel to everyone. It seems like everyone is pointing their fingers at me, calling me a criminal. I've lost my energy. I've become weak. Especially, Mehri's mother never gives me a moment's peace, scolding me, saying, “You worthless young man, you've ruined my daughter's name.” But these curses were of no use. They had to choose: either let me marry Mehri, or get rid of the child. Since her father was unaware of these secrets, he paid no attention to the pressure from her mother and stood firm in his decision. In the past two or three months, she hadn't stepped out of the house at all—not even once. With just a few days left until the long-awaited “guest” was due to be born, we hid Mehri from her father's eyes under the pretense that she had gone to visit her aunt in the countryside. It was there that the child

was born. After two or three days, Mehri regained her health. At that point, doing whatever it took to get rid of the baby had become a shared conviction among all of us.

As the story deepened, my pupils widened as if I were moving from darkness into light, from doubt into certainty – and my body tingled, as though sensing the approach of some terrifying encounter. As for the woman, she was hiding her eyes and quietly sobbing. My friend grew excited... A few seconds of silence filled the space between us. It was as if the silence would be broken by the sound of a fly buzzing its wings. My friend glanced at his wife. He paused for a moment, then continued:

—So, comrade doctor, brother, if I may tell you honestly, none of us had the heart to lose the child. He was just a bright, rosy-cheeked little boy. We thought of every possible way and trick from all sides. We considered giving him to a childless couple but feared the secret might be exposed. The idea came from Mehrikhan herself. She asked for my passport and went outside. I don't know what she did with the child. The next day, when I met to get news, the child was gone. As if she saw nothing. Her attitude towards me was cold. Mehri returned my passport to me. Inside it lay a copy of the divorce paper from the registry office, issued in my name. I was really astonished. We had not been officially married before. So, where did that divorce paper come from?

In brief, comrade doctor still hasn't told me what happened to the child. I still keep that divorce paper.

He took his passport out of his inside pocket. From inside the passport, he pulled out the historic divorce paper and handed it to me. My hands trembled as I took it. It was as if the dark fog that had been clouding my eyes for years

was slowly beginning to lift. This was the very divorce paper I had signed, the one that had caught me. I was powerless to gather the courage of my youth. My friend, who had grown suspicious of the changes in me, paused and stared at me in astonishment.

I turned my gaze to Mekhrikhan. These are those deceitful, unfaithful eyes: these are those ruby lips whose smile once scared away the pegions from the roof gutter of the mosque. Mehrikhon wiped her tear-swollen eyes with a silk handkerchief. The air in the room was thick with the scent of water-soaked cloves. I felt as if I were in the garden mosque seven years ago. Finally, I pulled myself together.

Seeing that I had calmed down, my friend began urging his wife:

— Mehrikhon, hey Mehrikhon! Come now, let it go – if he’s safe and sound, he’s probably grown up happily by now. And if he has died, the blame lies with the old way of life that was always ready to sew shrouds for people. This is my friend, the doctor – our fellow townsman. I really liked this man’s character. He’s a very friendly guy. Reveal the secret today, you’ve kept buried in your heart all these seven years. Let’s dig a grave for this story and tear it out of our hearts once and for all. You take care of yourself and don’t make yourself sick with worry, and I won’t keep eating myself up inside over you either.

The steady hands of a heavy silence seemed to press down on all three of our shoulders. It was as if the dark nights were linked together like chains, as if all three of us were waiting in that uncertainty for a single key to unlock a great magical chest. We waited, ears straining for a sound to



break the quiet. And I was gripped by a feeling that lasted seven years in time, but whose meaning stretched over seventy. I was engulfed in a struggle between vengeance and compassion, anger and mercy.

...There is Yadgar, still savoring the taste of his mother's milk, now peacefully sleeping in my arms...

...There is Yadgar, playing while wearing my star-covered hat.

...There is Yadgar, insisting, "Get me the bright white mum."

...There is Yadgar...

But now, Yadgar is gone.

Yadgar – he is someone else's child.

Oh, love, how powerful you are! The woman opened her eyes. With trembling hands, she grasped the edges of the bed and straightened up. In a trembling and emotional voice, she said: — Shall I say it?

— Shall I say it? I am responsible for the blood of a son and a young man!

She was half-mad. If emotion is the environment, then it is like a crippled ant caught in the waves of that environment...

In me, compassion overcame vengeance, love conquered anger; I was just like good-for-nothing of a long, silent orchard street shaded by peach trees over blind, rough walls.

I stood up and held Mehrikhan's both hands. I gathered all my strength into my eyes and gazed into her unfaithful, yet sorrowful, thorned, yet melancholic eyes:

Have you ever truly served someone selflessly?"

Mekhrikhon gave me a piercing stare. Shame was trampled underfoot, honor and dignity sold for a mere penny!

Was it you? Yes, it was you...

She embraced me tightly and fainted...

Now, I am in Tashkent. Yadgar is with me now,  
sometimes visits the Mehrikhon's family as well.

**G‘afur G‘ulom**

**Yodgor**

**Tarjimonlar:**

O‘ktam Qo‘ldoshov  
Maxbuba Mardiyeva

**Muharrir:**

Sherzod Isoqulov

**Sahifalovchi:**

Ahror Shamsiyev

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